



— EXPEDITION PSYCHOLOGY

The Fear of Falling Toolkit

Climb with more confidence and less fear.

— INTRODUCTION

Dr Fin Haley

I bring two worlds together — and this talk lives where they meet.

Clinical psychologist

Evidence-based tools for fear, anxiety, and how we respond under pressure.

Rock climbing instructor

Real time on the wall — I know the moment the fear arrives.



— WHAT WE'LL COVER

Today's outline

01

Understanding fear

What it is, and why it shows up when we climb.

02

Four practical tips

A way to practise falling that actually works.

03

Your questions

Overcoming the fear of falling, together.

— THE FAMILIAR PATTERN

Does this sound familiar?

Shouting “take”

Down-climbing

Avoiding routes entirely

Over-gripping

Backing off at your limit

All normal responses to fear — but the problem is, they keep the fear right where it is.



— MY STORY

This is me.

Raised on Peak District grit and alpine rock — and always scared of falling.

- Never pushed my grade
- Stayed well inside my comfort zone
- Drifted from the sport as friends went on to compete

— THE IDEA

What if I treated my fear like a phobia?

Psychology degree, meet climbing. I took the techniques used to treat phobias, turned them on my own fear of falling — and ran the experiment on myself.



— THE SCIENCE

First — what is fear?

The fight-or-flight response — a survival mechanism.

THE BODY

Prepares to move

Heart and breath race, vision narrows onto the danger, muscles tense.

THE MIND

Races ahead

Thoughts jump to the future.

THE URGE

Pushes us to act

The discomfort drives us to do something — and resolve the anxiety.

— ON THE WALL

The same system fires when we climb.

We learn to belay and clip — but we rarely test those systems. So we never learn the one thing that matters: it's OK to fall.



— EXERCISE · IN PAIRS

Turn to the person next to you.

Talk through your own fear of falling, using these four prompts.

Trigger

What situations set your fear off?

Body

How does your body react in that moment?

Thoughts

What goes through your mind?

Behaviour

What do you do in reaction to it?

— HOW FEAR SHOWS UP

The fear cycle in climbing

Trigger

A new route, far above a clip, a new partner.

Body

Over-grip, pump early, vision narrows, can't see the moves.

Thoughts

“What if I fall? Has my belayer got me?”

Behaviour

Down-climb, shout take, avoid the route entirely.

↻ **THE TRAP** Short term it works. But long term, the avoidance **maintains the fear**.

TIP 01

Notice how you avoid falling.

On your next climb at your limit, watch for the avoidance — and make it the focus of your attention.

A person with curly hair, wearing a yellow tank top and black pants, is climbing an indoor rock wall. They are holding a red rope. The wall is covered in various colored climbing holds (red, blue, yellow, black, purple) and has a large, dark, irregularly shaped rock formation on the right side. The background shows the interior of a climbing gym with a metal frame and other climbing equipment.

— THE PUZZLE

I exposed myself to falls.
So why hadn't the big
whips helped?

— THE MODEL

The window of tolerance

The range in which we can tolerate discomfort. It's personal — shaped by past experience and the resources we have that day.

Red — Panic Zone

Most heightened state. Can't think clearly, so we can't learn.

Amber — Learning Zone

Uncomfortable but coping. Return to green and the learning sticks.

Green — Calm Zone

At ease — but nothing new, so no learning happens.

— STRAIGHT TO RED

This is why the big lobs don't work.

Send yourself straight to the red zone and you're too panicked to process the fall as safe. No learning happens.

TIP 02

Don't throw yourself in at the deep end.

Grade your fall practice so it keeps you in the
amber — challenged, but able to cope.

— THERE'S MORE TO IT

This isn't the whole picture.

It's not just the intensity of your fall practice that matters — it's how long you stay with it. Fall practice needs to be prolonged.

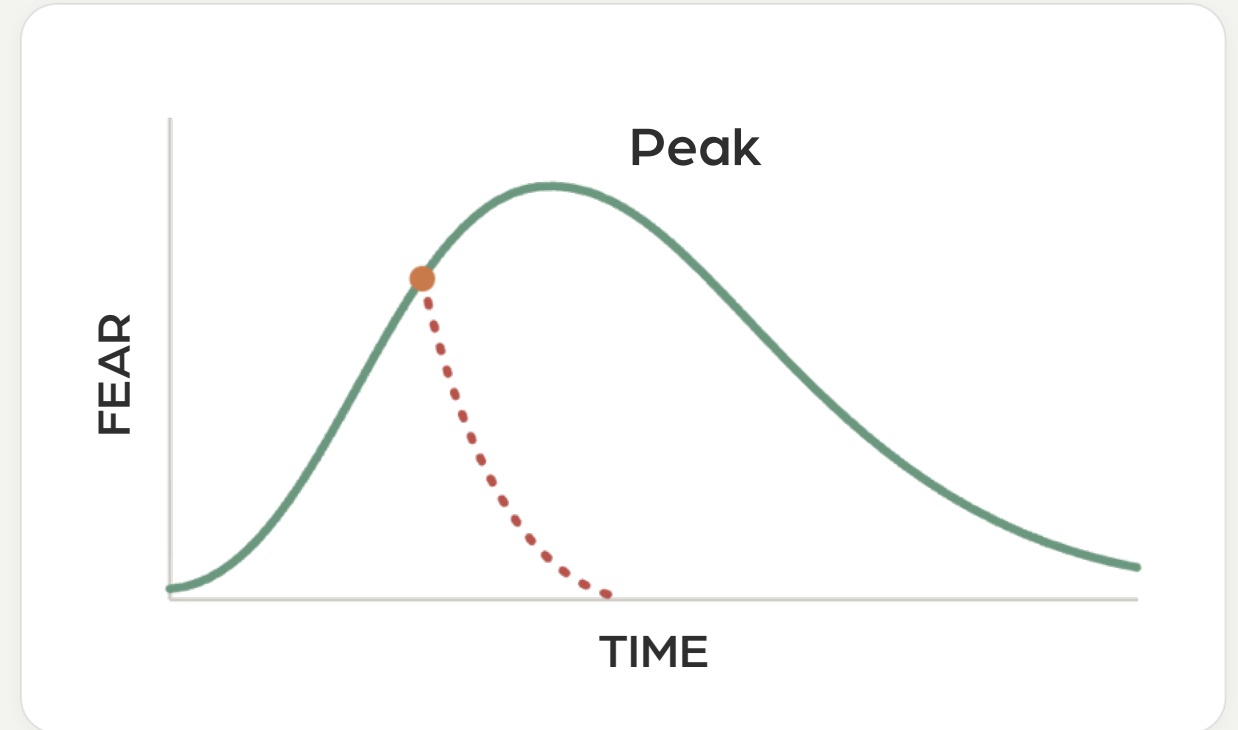


— DURATION MATTERS

Emotions come and go in waves.

Every wave has a start, a peak, and an end.

- Leave — fear drops, but it stays scary for next time.
- Stay with it — the anxiety subsides and you learn it's OK to fall.



TIP 03

Don't leave fall practice too early.

Ride the wave until the anxiety subsides. Leaving early only makes it worse.

— A CATCH

It worked — but only in one context.

I could fall in practice without much fear. But on real limit routes, the fear came back. My practice wasn't replicating real climbing.



— MAKE IT REAL

Add variety to your fall practice.

01 Fall from the side

02 Fall while throwing for a hold

03 Let your belayer call when to fall

04 Practise across different routes

TIP 04

Make sure your fall practice is varied.

Overcome the fear in the messy, unpredictable situations where it really shows up.

— BONUS TIP

When the risk is real.

There is an inherent risk within climbing — and for many of us, that's part of why we're drawn to the sport. But not every fall belongs in your fall practice.

— AN IMPORTANT LIMIT

Some falls don't belong in fall practice.

The relationship to falling here is different — the consequences are real, so exposure is the wrong tool.

Big lobs off high balls

Ground fall potential changes everything.

Repeated whips on trad gear

You're testing placements, not your fear.

— BEFORE YOU LEAVE THE GROUND

The decision framework

STEP 01

Assess the risk

What are the real consequences on this route?



STEP 02

Am I willing to accept them?

No

Back off, or change the plan.

Yes

Continue to step three.



STEP 03

Plan your response

Know your solution before you need it.

— BUILD IT GRADUALLY

A pyramid of experience.

You're not exposing yourself to falling here. Each solid layer lets you take on slightly bigger runouts, or slightly higher boulder problems.

At your limit

Bigger runouts

Committing but known

Well within your grade —
volume and mileage

— THE RECAP

Four tips, grounded in the evidence

Drawn from the most evidence-based therapy in the literature.

01 Notice your avoidance

02 Grade your fall practice

03 Do it for long enough

04 Keep it varied

— WHAT CHANGED FOR ME

I saw the benefits straight away.

More enjoyment in my climbing

Grades I never thought I could reach

Become a more positive presence

— THEN FRIENDS TRIED IT

They ran into the same difficulties.

01

Wrong pace

Not knowing when to move on — making it worse, or stagnating.

02

Lost motivation

Negative feelings around fall practice wore them down.

03

Unmanaged stress

Unsure how to deal with stress during practice.

04

No clear plan

Fall practice sat outside their other sessions.

— THE MISSING PIECE

Knowing the tips isn't the same as doing them.

You need to do fall practice consistently enough for it to work — and that takes more skills:

A clear exposure ladder

Setting goals

Reflecting on your zone

Planning the exercise in

Cognitive calming techniques

— THE FEAR OF FALLING TOOLKIT

Three skill sets, one toolkit.



Fin — clinical content

Wrote the course content from a climbing & psychology perspective.



Sam — videography

Filmed the 24 videos. Has worked with Mammut, Alpkite, and climbers like Steve McClure.



Abi — the app

Climber and software engineer. Built the app for goals, reflection, and progress.

— WITH THEIR SUPPORT

Developed with The Foundry and Mammut.



They gave us their full support, and helped us develop the course using their kit and facilities.

— ALREADY CHANGING CLIMBERS

"Climbs I used to get mega pumped on earlier this season are now easy warm ups — and I've since climbed my hardest grade."

Filippa

"Before the course the difference between my top rope and lead climbing grade was 3 grades — now it's just half a grade."

Nessa

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